

Zero to Launch: Buy a Business on a Budget

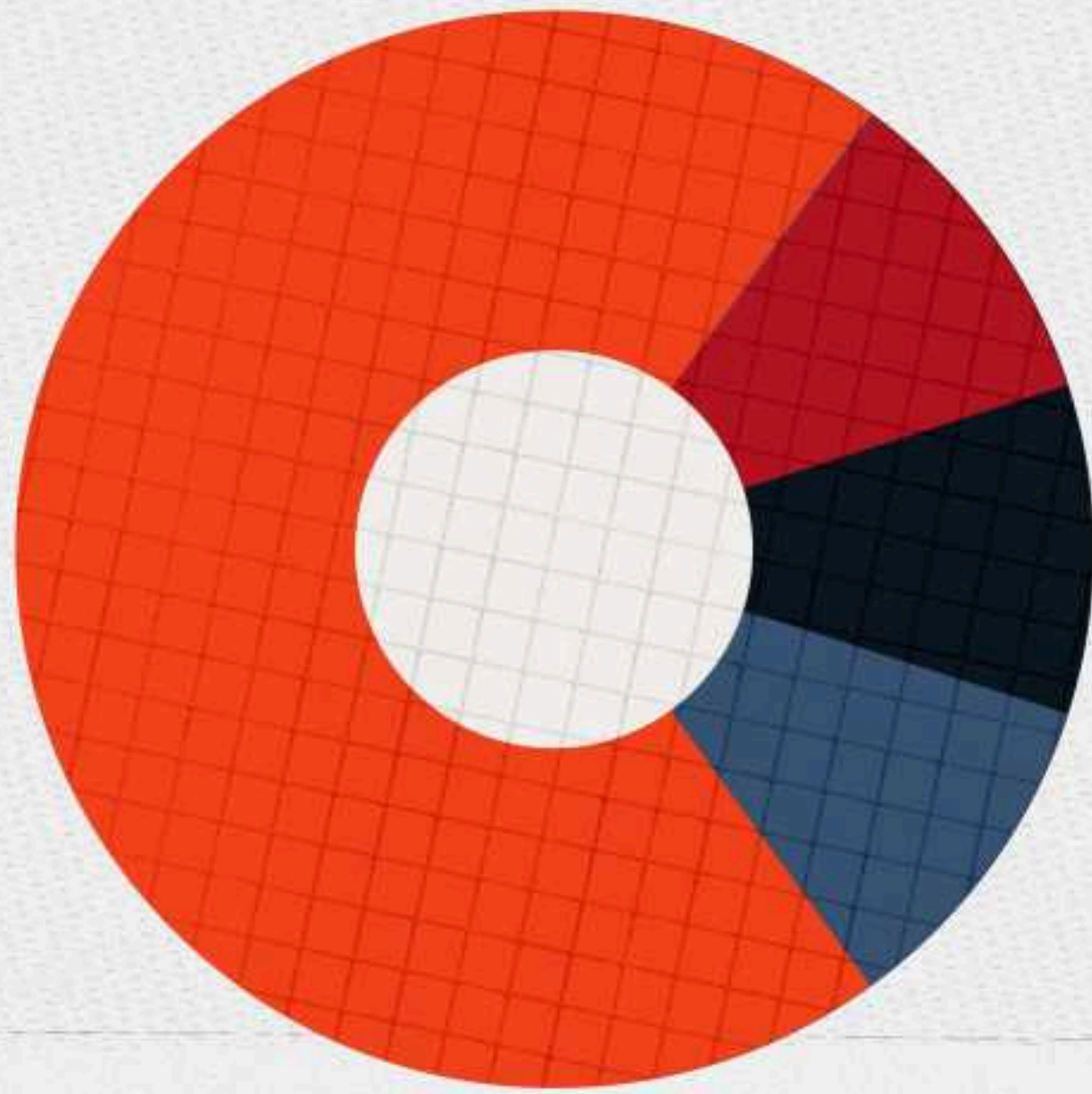
Buying an existing business skips the riskiest phase of starting one from scratch. With smart financing and a scrappy search strategy, **you can become an owner-operator on a budget.**

SMART MONEY ALLOCATION

Where your limited funds should go:

70%

Financing structure
(bank loan, seller financing,
down payment)



Tip: You don't need to find a listing — many great deals are with owners who haven't even thought about selling yet.

10%

Deal discovery
+ diligence tools

10%

Legal/accounting review

10%

Working capital

ESSENTIAL TOOLS

Save ~\$500+ by using DIY-friendly deal tools:

FUNCTION	PREMIUM TOOL	FREE/LOW-COST ALTERNATIVE
Deal Discovery	BizBuySell Pro (\$49/mo)	BizBuySell (Free), MicroAcquire (Free)
Financial Review	CPA Firm (\$250/hr)	Google Sheets + Templates, Bench trial
Communication Tracking	HubSpot CRM (\$50+/mo)	Streak CRM (Free), Notion + Gmail
Video Walkthroughs	Loom Teams (\$12.50/mo)	Loom (Free tier)
Deal Tracking	DealRoom (\$150/mo)	Google Sheets, Notion Deal Pipeline

QUICK-WIN TACTICS

- **Owner outreach:** DM 10 small business owners/week with a short ask
- **Use broker listings as Intel:** Even if you don't buy there, they reveal niches + price comps
- **The Sarah Moore method:** Structure deals using 75% bank loan + 25% seller financing
- **Reverse engineering:** See what it takes to [sell a business](#), to help figure out what you need to look for in a potential acquisition target

ACTION STEPS

- ☐ Write down your ideal business profile (industry, size, location)
- ☐ Identify 10 businesses in that category and reach out cold
- ☐ Build a basic CRM in Notion or Google Sheets
- ☐ Review 1–2 sample P&Ls and practice napkin math analysis
- ☐ Save a deal template or LOI draft to prep for your first real lead

THE 3-STEP LAUNCH

STEP 1: VALIDATE (\$0)

- Define your target criteria (niche, location, profit level, etc.)
- Reach out to 50 business owners (even if they aren't "for sale")
- Use a napkin math template to qualify leads
- **Goal:** Find 3 warm conversations worth pursuing

STEP 2: RESEARCH (≤\$300)

- Use free CRM to track deal conversations
- Ask for 2–3 years of P&Ls and basic docs
- Analyze key metrics: SDE, churn, dependencies, retention
- Draft LOI with help from templates or legal advice

STEP 3: BUY (\$100–\$500)

- Line up financing: SBA, seller note, partner, or loan
- Negotiate terms + transition plan with seller
- Sign and close — then go all-in on onboarding, operations, and retention

"Anyone who wants to buy and operate a small business can do so. It is not a matter of can or can't, it's a matter of will or won't. To me it's one of the few areas left of the American dream where you can go out and just put in a ton of effort and elbow grease, and make something of your life." — **Sarah Moore, EggCartons.com**